

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Jonah

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The book of Jonah is well known for its amazing events, but its main purpose is to teach us about God. Through Jonah's experience, God (the all-powerful Creator) shows that he judges wickedness. But God also gladly shows mercy to people who repent, even to those we may think do not deserve mercy.

Setting

Jonah was a prophet in the northern kingdom of Israel during the rule of Jeroboam II. Jeroboam II ruled from 793 to 753 BC. This was a time of political success but spiritual darkness. Even though Jeroboam did evil in God's sight (see 2 Kings 14:23–24), Israel's borders expanded, just as Jonah had predicted (2 Kings 14:25). Israel became nearly as large as it had been during the days of David and Solomon (see 1 Kings 8:65). During this time, great national pride was growing in Israel.

At the same time, Nineveh was an important city in the Assyrian Empire. Assyria had become very powerful in earlier years. King Sargon II of Assyria ruled from 722 to 705 BC. He expanded Assyria's control into Palestine. Assyrian records say that Sargon fought against King Ahab of Israel and other kings at the battle of Qarqar in 853 BC (1 Kings 17:1–22:53).

But during the reigns of Jehoash (798–782 BC) and Jeroboam II (793–753 BC), Assyria became weaker because of poor leadership and resistance from other nations. Jonah likely preached in Nineveh during this weaker period, around 755 BC.

Years after Jonah's visit, Assyria became powerful again under Tiglath-pileser III. He ruled from 744 to 727 BC. In 722 BC, Assyria destroyed Samaria and ended the northern kingdom of Israel. About one hundred years later, the prophet Nahum of Judah announced that Nineveh and the Assyrian Empire would soon be destroyed because of their great wickedness. The Babylonians destroyed Nineveh in 612 BC. This shows that the repentance that followed Jonah's preaching did not last.

Summary

The book of Jonah has two main parts.

Chapters 1–2 describe Jonah's first response to God's command to warn Nineveh about coming judgment because of its wickedness. Instead of going to Nin-

veh, Jonah boarded a ship and traveled in the opposite direction (1:3). God sent a violent storm to discipline him. The pagan sailors tried desperately to satisfy whichever god they thought was angry. Eventually, Jonah was identified as the cause of the trouble and was thrown into the sea. Then God calmed the storm.

In an ironic turn, the pagan sailors worshiped God while Jonah appeared to be heading toward death. But God planned to save Jonah. A great fish swallowed him, and inside the fish, Jonah apparently repented (chapter 2). After three days and nights, the fish released Jonah onto dry land.

Chapters 3–4 describe God's second command for Jonah to preach in Nineveh. This time Jonah obeyed. The people of Nineveh repented after hearing Jonah's warning (chapter 3). God did not bring the judgment Jonah had announced (3:10).

Again, there is irony in the story. Jonah became angry because God showed mercy to Israel's enemies. Jonah moved from anger to despair (chapter 4). God used a plant to teach Jonah another lesson. The plant quickly grew to give Jonah shade and then quickly died.

The book ends suddenly with God asking Jonah a question: Should God not care about a great city like Nineveh and want its people to receive mercy instead of judgment?

Author

The book does not name its author. The title comes from the main character, Jonah. Jonah himself or one of his associates may have written it.

Genre

Unlike most prophetic books, Jonah is mainly a story rather than a collection of prophecies. Some people have argued that the book is fictional because it includes miracles. Others have described it as a parable or teaching story. However, the book presents itself as a real historical account (see 1:1). It is best understood as historical narrative that also teaches important truths about God.

Meaning and Message

Jonah is different from the other prophetic books because it tells how God sent a prophet to Assyria, Israel's enemy, and how many people repented as a result.

Jonah learned a lesson that all Israel needed to learn: "Salvation is from the LORD!" (2:9). God alone decides

whom he will save. People who have received God's mercy should not try to prevent others (even their enemies) from receiving that same mercy (see chapter 4).

The book also teaches that salvation and judgment are connected to God's rule over all things. God saved the sailors by calming the storm. He saved Jonah from drowning by sending the fish. There is no place, even deep in the sea, where God cannot rescue people. In the same way, there is no nation beyond God's power either to judge (3:4, 9) or to save from judgment (3:10; see Jeremiah 18:7-10).

The book of Jonah also shows that God's desire to save people from all nations existed long before Christ came. Israel was God's covenant people (a people bound to him by a special agreement), but from the beginning God planned to bless all nations through Israel (see Genesis 12:3). God wants people everywhere to turn away from idols to know him, the God of heaven who created the world (Jonah 1:9; see 2 Peter 3:9).